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Miron Białoszewski, Lech Emfazy Stefański, and the Paranormal: Toward a History of a Peculiar Relationship

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ABSTRACT

Miron Białoszewski, an acclaimed Polish poet and playwright, and Lech Emfazy Stefański, a poet, dramatist, director, and since the early 1970s a key parapsychologist in Poland, met first shortly after World War II. They shared a passion for avant-garde theatre, literature, and music, and were also interested in psychic phenomena which, though, manifested itself in their lives and writings with quite different intensities. This article seeks to provide an introduction to the role of the esoteric elements in their biographies, while at the same time situating their relationship against the background of political and cultural changes in communist Poland. The first part of the paper outlines Białoszewski's and Stefański's youth experiences and their collaboration in the Theatre at Tarczyńska Street. The second part of the article addresses Stefański's contribution to the propagation of psychotronics in Poland; it also touches upon his literary texts; while the last section examines the encounters of the former collaborators in the 1970s, placing emphasis on the role of the blind poetess Jadwiga Stańczakowa in bringing the two men back together.

KEYWORDS

Esotericism; the paranormal; friendship; literature; communist Poland

Introduction and Aims

At first glance, Miron Białoszewski (1922–1983) and Lech Emfazy Stefański (1928–2010) do not seem to have much in common. While Białoszewski is not only a canonical author, but also an iconic figure for admirers of Warsaw and the Polish LGBT + community¹, the latter is known mainly to the occult² milieu. However, both protagonists developed strong personal and professional ties between 1947 and 1958, and they renewed their acquaintance in the mid-1970s. They shared a lot in common: love for literature, music, theatre and ritual ceremonies; interests and activities that did not fit into the socialist canon; charismatic personalities; and a strong need for recognition. Both were persistent in pursuing their ideas and successful in doing so. In the era when dialectical materialism dominated the intellectual discourse in the Eastern bloc, they were looking for a deeper sense of reality, but beyond traditional religious structures. This, combined with their talent for rallying people around them, helped them to create their own niches that can be considered in terms of 'dropping out of socialism'³, although they did not strive to completely cut themselves off from the mainstream.⁴